

Chiromantis xerampelina

Gray foam-nest frog



Length 2–3½ in (5–9 cm)
Habit Mostly arboreal
Breeding Rainy season
season
Status Least concern

Location Southern Africa



This tree frog and its close relatives are remarkable for their breeding method and their ability to

survive in savanna that has a long dry season. Its skin is adapted to reduce water loss, and it excretes dry droppings rather than watery waste. Usually gray or pale brown, this frog can change color for camouflage—at night it is usually dark-colored, but it can become almost white at midday.

LIVING IN TREES

The gray foam-nest frog has a compact body and prominent eyes with horizontal pupils. It possesses the typical adaptations for an arboreal lifestyle: long, slender limbs, and adhesive disks on all its toes. Its fingers and toes are also webbed.



BUILDING A COMMUNAL FOAM NEST

During the breeding season, the male gray foam-nest frog—which can be distinguished from the female by the pads he develops on the first and second toes of his forelimbs—calls out to females from branches overhanging a pool. He may be joined in this by one or more other males. When a female arrives, one of the males clasps her, they mate, and

she produces a secretion that one or several males whip into a foam with their legs. The female then ejects her eggs—up to 1,200 at a time—into the foam, and one or more of the males shed sperm onto them. The exterior of the nest hardens to protect the eggs, but the inside remains moist. After the eggs hatch, the tadpoles burrow out of the nest and fall into the water below.

*Breviceps adspersus*

Bushveld rain frog



Length 1¼–2¼ in (3–6 cm)
Habit Terrestrial
Breeding Rainy season
season
Status Least concern

Location Southern Africa



The bushveld rain frog lives mostly underground, emerging to feed and mate only after rain. It has a stout body—either light or dark brown, with rows of lighter, yellowish or orange patches with dark borders—and short, stout limbs typical of most burrowing species. When cornered, this frog inflates its body

and lodges itself firmly in its burrow. The females are much larger than the males. Since the male is too small to clasp the female during mating, the female emits a secretion from her back that acts as a glue, keeping the mating pair together.

*Paedophryne amauensis*

Paedophryne amauensis



Length ¼–¾ in (7–8 mm)
Habit Terrestrial
Breeding Not recorded
season
Status Not evaluated

Location Papua New Guinea



Paedophryne amauensis is a tiny frog, found in only one locality in Papua New Guinea. Its upper sides are dark brown with irregular patches, and the belly is

brown or gray with a blue–white speckled pattern. It has a broad head and relatively long legs, and is capable of jumping 30 times its own body length. Discovered in 2009, *P. amauensis* is considered by some scientists to be the smallest vertebrate species in the world.

*Phrynomantis bifasciatus*

Banded rubber frog



Length 1½–2¼ in (4–6 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding Rainy season
season
Status Least concern

Location Southern Africa



Unusually for a frog, the short-legged banded rubber frog walks and runs rather than hops or jumps. It is black and glossy, with mainly pink or red spots and stripes down its back; these change color throughout the day, turning paler in bright light. Its head is pointed, and it has small eyes with round pupils. This frog feeds on insects, mainly termites and ants. If threatened, it raises itself on outstretched limbs and inflates its body. It also produces a highly toxic substance from its skin, which may be lethal to humans if ingested. Males produce a trilling courtship call from the pond edge, and females lay clumps of up to 600 eggs, which they attach to aquatic plants.

Gastrophryne olivacea

Great Plains narrow-mouthed toad



Length ¾–1½ in (2–4 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding Spring and
season summer
Status Least concern

Location C. and S. USA,
N. Mexico



Also known as the Western narrow-mouthed toad, this species has a narrow, pointed head with small eyes, a stout body, and short legs that allow it to burrow and hide in small crevices. Brown or gray in color, it is sometimes distinguished by the dark, leaf-shaped pattern on the surface of its back. In spring, after heavy rain, Great Plains narrow-mouthed toads are known to gather in large numbers around temporary pools. The males call out to the females, making a protracted buzzing sound. After mating, the females lay their eggs in the pool. The tadpoles develop rapidly, before the water dries up.

